gesture—the 'one big thought'. "I was surprised when he suggested developing satellite towns like Noida to take burden off capital Jaipur, for which he has already announced a big network of flyovers, elevated roads and a Metro," says an officer in the know.

Officials privy to his meetings with Union ministers and BJP CMs say that, rather than these being mere courtesy calls, he succeeds in extracting one or the other extra benefit for the state. These include agreements with Haryana and MP to get surplus water, and with Chhattisgarh for coal, besides a nod from the Union energy ministry for additional power. Long years in the organisation have given him recognition and access at a level that people outside don't realise, and he's parlaying it off to Rajasthan's advantage. But this sense of being a quiet doer has yet to filter through the state's own portrait gallery of heavyweights. Here, he is still work in progress.

The word on Sharma's functioning style and personality comes from bureaucrats, who see him up close regularly, as also cabinet members and MLAs. There is near-unanimity: he carries no baggage and looks at past policy with no prejudice, instead evincing a broad-minded tilt towards any enduring positive. The inexperience still shows, but the glaring instances have tapered off significantly, and he's not shy about learning the technicalities from officers, such as about finance. "Initially, we wondered why he took time to clear even simple files," says a senior bureaucrat. "Now we see he wants to understand things. That's good: an inexperienced CM is often prone to be led by bureaucrats. They will get signs and notings on files out of you that you may regret later."

Officials, too, are treading with caution. Barring half a dozen veterans who began their career under Bhairon Singh Shekhawat, the entire administrative set-up has seen just two models of governance, that of Ashok Gehlot and Vasundhara Raje, since 1998. Their likes and dislikes were well known. With Sharma, they have no settled habits to cater to. His initial interactions offered no clue either, being more in the vein of a leader motivating his troops. "We found that amusing, a chief minister giving us a politician-type address," says an officer. The leaning towards oratory hasn't ebbed—even the Opposition applauded two of his assembly speeches. But Sharma is feeling his way through administration. He's to be found at his office in Civil Secretariat almost every day he's in town—his predecessors mostly stuck to Work From Home.

A POLITICAL MINEFIELD

Redefining equations with ministers and MLAs he had interacted with as a low-key partyman is dicey too. They expect a similar access and flavour in relationships. As their boss, he hasn't retreated into an ivory tower—he tries to treat them like colleagues and often cites his non-elite fellowship, but has been subtly using that as a lever to seek performance and frugality. He quizzes them about files, and has asked a few to cut down on frills, citing how he retained old furniture at his official Civil Lines residence instead of indulging himself with renovations. For travel at late hours, he prefers not to incur the cost of a pilot. "All my life I have travelled by road or train, mostly by night. Why can't I do it now?" Sharma asks.

The Opposition, far stronger than anything Raje faced in her two tenures, is in no mood to rush in with plaudits, of course. Says leader of Opposition Tika Ram Jully: "He's a good man, but a weak administrator." Sharma merely smiles that off. Health minister Gajendra Singh Khimswar, a Raje-era cabinet veteran since 2003 who takes most questions about the CM's departments, is eager to counter all easy stereotyping: "The CM wants to get off the blocks fast and break the notion that the government is not doing anything." A few other colleagues confirm that basically he's a nice person and then offer the caveat: "Power changes people's nature, we must wait



INTERVIEW
BHAJAN LAL SHARMA

"Politics and ideology is one thing, I like restraint in language"

A career mostly spent in district-level work for saffron couldn't have schooled BHAJAN LAL SHARMA for the office of Rajasthan CM. Trouble does not cease: an LS poll setback, imminent bypolls, rivals waiting to see him fail. But he's learning to walk the "double-edged sword", as he tells Deputy Editor Rohit Parihar: